

First Battle of Petersburg

In June, Butler blundered again. Having heard that Petersburg might be very lightly defended, because most of Beauregard's forces were in the Bermuda Hundred lines, Butler sought to win some long-overdue military laurels by raiding the city. On June 9, 3,400 infantrymen and 1,300 cavalymen crossed the Appomattox River and approached the Dimmock Line, as Petersburg's encircling fortifications were called. While the tocsins (alarm bells) rang in the city, calling the militia to arms, the assaulting infantrymen were too intimidated by the frowning parapets and redoubts to mount an attack. Instead they pulled back to the safety of Bermuda Hundred.

A few miles away Butler's cavalry was in a severe fight. Storming the southern part of the Dimmock Line along the Jerusalem Plank Road, they came up against the Battalion of Virginia Reserves—125 “gray-haired sires and beardless youths,” including city councilmen, shopkeepers, and teenagers—led by the retired Colonel Fletcher H. Archer, a veteran of the War with Mexico. In what became famous as the “Battle of Old Men and Young Boys,” this scratch force, many armed only with ancient muskets, repulsed repeated assaults for nearly two hours. Even hospital patients helped fight the Union horsemen who finally also retreated to Bermuda Hundred.

60 The percentage of Fletcher H. Archer's Battalion of Virginia Reserves killed, wounded, or taken prisoner in the “Battle of Old Men and Young Boys,” June 9, 1864.

Valley defeats

Grant's plans for a Shenandoah Valley offensive had been thwarted, too. In May, General Franz Sigel's army was first bogged down by rain, then saw action at New Market. This was one of the handsome towns through which the Valley Turnpike rolled, as did the road leading east across the Blue Ridge Mountains and down into the cockpit where Lee and Grant were slugging it out. Lee believed Sigel would use that route to attack his flank, and on Sunday, May 15, General John C. Breckinridge was trying to prevent that.

Cannonfire had driven many of New Market's residents into the cellars, but the noise was even more terrifying because